Witness

By Peter Maloney

Place: Abu Ghraib Prison, Iraq *Time: April 2004*

[Sound of metal door slamming very loudly. At same time lights bump up. Shouts of prisoners, dogs barking somewhere.] [KASIM sits on the lower bunk of an iron bed. There is no mattress, only a plywood board. KASIM wears an orange jumpsuit. He holds a baseball in one hand and regards it. He opens his mouth wide, as if he wants to take a bite of the baseball. He looks up at us.]

KASIM: **It** occurs to me ... perhaps they thought we *eat* these things. That they thought it is some kind of fruit, and that we eat it. I could have told them that *this* is not indigenous to Iraq, that baseballs do not grow on trees here. And that, in any case, it is not a fruit. But they do not speak my language. And the translator was not there when they tried to feed it to me. *[KASIM looks at the baseball. He opens his mouth as wide as possible. He closes his mouth, looks at us.]* **It** barely fit into my mouth. They had to break two teeth to get it in. *[He opens his mouth wide again, points with a finger to broken teeth in back.]* I tried to spit the baseball out, to push it out with my tongue, but they tied a scarf around my head to hold it in.

With the baseball in my mouth, I could only breathe through my nose. **It** was fortunate for me that it was not the season of my asthma, or I might have suffocated. I was frightened, and I wanted to tell them about my asthma, but the baseball in my mouth made it impossible for me to speak.

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INTRODUCTION

In the era of Saddam Hussein, Abu Ghraib, twenty miles west of Baghdad, was one of the world's most notorious prisons, with torture, weekly executions, and vile living conditions. As many as fifty thousand men and women—no accurate count is possible—were jammed into Abu Ghraib at one time, in twelve-by-twelve-foot cells that were little more than human holding pits But then, after 24 years as the brutal ruler of Iraq and nine months as a fugitive, Saddam Hussein was captured in a US Military raid on December 13, 2003. U.S. forces took over the prison, and renamed it the Baghdad Central Detention Center. Beginning in 2004, accounts of physical and psychological torture, and sexual abuse of prisoners held in the Abu Ghraib prison in came to public attention. These acts were committed by military police personnel of the United States Army. Meet Kasim – a detainee ready to bear . . . Witness by Peter Maloney

KASIM: I was abducted on the day the Americans captured Saddam. I was with my friend Ameen. The news of Saddam's capture had just come over the TV: I closed up my shop and we ran out into the street. The TV in the window we left on so that people outside could watch the events as they unfolded. I had loaned Ameen my video camera. He was making a film about the situation here. At the time of the invasion, he had filmed the falling statues, and now he wanted to film the people's reaction to the fall of the man himself. The reaction of the man in the street. We were hurrying along the river in the direction of the AI-Salam Palace. There were so many people, all of them shouting, dancing in the streets. American soldiers sitting atop their Humvees, grinning, smoking cigarettes. I was so happy to see Saddam go away. You know he destroyed our country. He humiliated us. I thank you, President Bush.

There was one tank on the street. Ameen laughs and says, "Hey, it's Clint Eastwood's tank." I look, and even with my bad English I can make out, stenciled on the barrel of the big gun: "GO AHEAD, MAKE MY DAY." I am standing right by the tank. Ameen was taking pictures of all the action when somebody behind us starts shooting at the Americans. I hear the firing and the bullets hitting

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the tank and I ducked down. It becomes a kind of instinct. I know *they* are likely to fire grenades next, so I drop to the ground. Now an American soldier has his foot on my back and his rifle pushing hard behind my ear and he is screaming at me in English. The tank is shaking and I hear explosions, and sure enough Clint is firing the big gun in the direction the shots came from.

I am lying on my stomach with this boot on my back and the barrel of the gun pushing my head into the pavement and then my video camera joins me there on the ground, all the pieces of it clattering into the gutter. Before I know it my hands are tied together behind my back with the plastic laces and I am being pulled up onto my feet. Ameen is up against the tank, another soldier's got him covered. His hands are tied, too, and he has a sandbag over his head.

They took us in a Humvee, with other guys they rounded up. To Camp Cropper, out near the airport. They put us in a tent. I didn't see Ameen again. *[He is quiet [or a moment, then, suddenly agitated, he stands and, looking up as if to the upper tier of cells, cries out in a loud voice.]*

We were in the tent for eight days. Bagged and cuffed. That was in December. It was cold. No one in the tent knew why we were there. Somebody in the tent knew some English and he asked the soldiers why we were there. They told us we knew why. But we didn't know. They said they were the ones who ask the questions and if they didn't like the answers they'd send us all to Guantanamo. They kept saying we were going to Guantanamo, that once we were there we'd be wishing we were back here.

So when they are loading us into the truck to move us out, this soldier pulls me

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aside, holds me back. Everybody is in the back of the truck but me, they're packed in, cuffed and bagged, and the soldier is ready to put a bag on my head. But before he does he takes out his wallet and flips through some pictures he keeps in there. There's his mother and his wife or his girlfriend and his kid or his little brother, I don't know, and he finds the picture he's looking for. He puts his hand on my shoulder like we are buddies and he holds out the wallet with the picture for me to see. It's a picture of him in a red and black checked cap. He's holding a rifle, (an ordinary rifle, not the big gun he's carrying now), and tied across the front of his truck is a deer. He's holding on to the horn of this big deer and looking proud of himself. *[Change of tone, more intimate. It is important to KASIM that we know what he thinks about this.]*

The next thing I know I'm in the dark again and being lifted up, and they throw me across the front of the truck and tie me down. The soldiers are laughing and at first I'm not minding being tied down because the truck has been idling for a while and I am suddenly warmer than I have been in over a week. But by the time we are halfway to Abu Ghraib the hood is red hot and the metal is burning me right through my shirt and my pants. *[He touches his jumpsuit very gingerly with his fingertips around his middle, his thighs.]*

Can you do something for me? Maybe you can get in touch with my family? Tell my wife where I am. That I'm OK. Five months, man. Five months, and I still don't know what they want from me.

In the middle of the trip here, a sandstorm hit, and I was really glad for the sandbag on my head, which protected me somewhat. When we got here, they untied me, took the bag off, and this ... unearthly light was everywhere, because

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of the dust. Everything was *ghamidh.* You know this word? Mysterious. Ambiguous. Yeah.

When we got here we finally could take a shower. They took our clothes away. They took everything away. My watch. The thing is, I wonder if it's really five months, or does it just seem that way? They can do crazy things with time, you know. Stop it, practically. What if it's only been five *hours?* What if they haven't even noticed I'm gone?

I'm not supposed to tell what happened here. They say you wouldn't understand. But it's not right to do these things to people! Without permission, and without explaining anything! It's inhuman. Of course they aren't human, that's the thing. They can disguise themselves. As anything.

I've seen things you wouldn't believe. That's why we aren't supposed to tell you. Because you wouldn't believe it. It's not the time for you to begin believing. I don't know why they picked me. I guess they think it's time for me.
Their ships are sometimes disguised as helicopters. You can tell by the light. It is the brightest light you've ever seen. You can't look into it without it hurting. I don't think they *want* to hurt us. They forced me to lie down. In a cubicle. It was cool and damp and it smelled bad. They put the bright light on me and looked me over. All over. They seemed quite concerned, about my burns from the truck. They checked me all over to see if I was hurt. Because I *was* hurt. It was like I was paralyzed. There was never just one of them. They were always with another one, or in a group. They *looked* human, most of them. Humanoid, I guess is what they are. They just touch you with their hand or an instrument and you go numb. At first it hurts a lot, for an instant, but then it doesn't hurt

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at all. You can't feel anything, and you can't move. You just lie there. You can't believe that you are just lying there, not saying anything, not protesting, but you can't. You just can't. Sometimes there are computers there and the beings are putting data into the computers while they do these things to you. And they are always taking pictures. There are balconies, and sometimes there are other beings watching from above. There isn't much furniture. You can't always tell by looking at them whether they are male or female, but somehow, you just ... know. The shorter ones are the helpers. The taller ones are in charge. That is definite. The small ones especially stare at you. It is dangerous to look at them. Somehow you know that, so you try not to look in their eyes.

They show us pictures, wide-screen, 360 degrees. In 3-D, no special glasses required. Pictures of things we see all the time, but stopped noticing. The gutters running like sewers; the marshlands disappeared; the pipelines burning in Kuwait; the sky black with smoke. We tried to tell them that it isn't all our fault. That Saddam did a lot of this. That the sanctions did a lot of it. Then the Americans, and in reaction to the Americans. But they didn't want to hear any excuses. They know the Garden of Eden, the original *Janat Adn* was *just a few miles from here!* From where we are standing, did you know that? Oh, yes, they know what they are doing by coming here. And they want us to realize what we are doing to the earth. If they are going to come here and take over, well, there has to be something left, after all. Something they can use.

I don't have much time left, but I will tell you what I think. I think that these beings may be ... angels. I think they are beings between us and God. It is not always easy to recognize them. Last night the visitant was E.T. Right here in my cell. I knew there was going to be another examination when they brought

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out the sheets and blankets and hung them over the bars so that no one could see in. I appreciate that. Privacy is good. They made me strip, which I hate to do, but I have gotten somewhat used to it. They needed to take another sample of some kind, I suppose. They never say. Four of them held me down, face down on the bunk here. Then E.T. was there. I recognized him, even though he was wearing fatigues like the others. He is short and ugly and his head is too big for his body and his eyes are huge. He looked at me. I tried not to look at him. He held up his finger and waved it back and forth in front of my face until I looked up. He was smiling, and his finger was glowing because he was E.T.
Then he put the glowing finger up my . . . . *[He struggles with what he is feeling.]*
It hurt and I cried out for God's help.

I believe I am leaving here tonight. They have examined me. All tests have been done, and the results are in. I've been inoculated against smallpox and diphtheria. There is no history of liver disease in my family. I have assured them of my complete cooperation. Tonight the impossible light will come down at the proper angle to form a ramp of energy from here to there. A guide will float us up the ramp straight ... through ... the bars.

AMEEN! ... YOUR FRIEND IS NOT MAD!

Straight through the bars to the ship, which is waiting for us. It will be ... as if ... I am a full bucket, pulled up from the well's darkness, then lifted out and up into the light.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: ***Peter Maloney***
Book: ***Found in The Best American Short Plays 2006-2007***
ISBN: 978-1557837486
Publisher: ***Applause Theatre and Cinema Books***
Date (Month/Year): ***April 2010***

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